



More often than not, buying a new PC brings up the dilemma of whether you should opt for the slightly expensive branded system, or settle for a locally assembled PC. The price factor has always been a sore point that has kept the humble masses away from branded PCs. However, branded players are trying their best to cut the stranglehold of the assembled PCs by offering machines priced below Rs 25,000. Festive seasons also play a part in determining the pricing policies, and you will find a whole lot of goodies—not to mention the astonishingly low price—given along with these PCs to increase sales.

With the recent attempts at providing entry-level PCs at a price comparable to that of an assembled PC, doubts have been raised about the quality of these systems. Our branded PC test covered seven brands and 12 contenders that were priced in the range of a paltry Rs 20,000 to an enormous Rs 60,000.

The Branded PC market has been dominated largely by the likes of HP-Compaq, IBM, HCL, Zenith, PCS and lately by Dell, LG and Samsung. There are many other local brands such as Datamini, Dart, etc., who also make their presence felt in this highly competitive market. Most computers were in the Rs 30,000 to 35,000

bracket. There were certain exceptions such as the Value PC from Zenith that was priced at an attractive Rs 20,000. After putting these PCs through our rigorous tests, it was clear that the quality standards maintained by some vendors still holds true in some cases; as for the rest, they were no better than the run-of-the-mill assembled machines.

We divided the computers into two categories—the first was the entry-level bracket that included PCs priced up to Rs 50,000. The second category consisted of PCs above Rs 50,000 and formed the mid-tier PC section.

Those who did not make it

We missed out on brands such as Dell, IBM and Acer, much to our disappointment.

IBM refused to send their PCs, just like the last time.

Acer was willing to send their machines, provided we did individual reviews instead of comparisons.

Dell's PCs are built as per customer-requests, and only brought in after a confirmed order—this takes about a month.

Ingram Micro released their latest computer-line on the 16th October—too late to be included.



How We Tested

Apart from a distinctive logo, the branded PCs we received had a national presence, with authorised service centres in at least all the metropolises. All of the systems were tested on Windows XP, though some of them were bundled with Linux. This created a common testing platform that yielded results that could be directly compared with each other. Peripherals such as monitors and speakers were also tested. The testing procedure involved three primary parameters—features, performance and value for money—with appropriate weightages given to each.

Features

Features comprised 45 per cent of the overall scores. The features score of a PC was based on how it performed in the four sub-sections.

System configuration and bundled peripherals: Specifications such as the processor type, the amount of RAM, hard disk type, motherboard, the presence of a CD, DVD, or CD-RW drive, graphics card, motherboard etc., were noted. Extra points were given for the presence of additional peripherals such as gamepads, good speakers, etc.

Build quality: Here, we logged aspects such as the overall layout of the components, roominess and airflow within the chassis through additional fans and ducts. The sturdiness of the CD or DVD drive tray, the quality and feel of the buttons, mouse and keyboard, build quality of flaps over the front USB ports, etc., were also observed. Easy accessibility to the interior of the chassis was considered as a plus.

Upgrade: We recorded the extent to which the processor and the RAM could be upgraded. We also looked for the AGP slot, the PCI slots and the number of USB and serial ports. The presence of bays to accommodate additional hard disks and optical drives such as DVD drives, CD-Writers, etc., was also checked.

Package contents: Here, we took a look at the documentation and software bundled along with the system. The inclusion or exclusion of contents such as the OS installation CD or restore disk, free software, driver CDs, manuals, setup guides, power cables, etc., was also taken into account.

Performance

Performance made up the remaining 55 per cent of the overall score. We used a battery of benchmarking software to evaluate the performance of the processor, the memory, the graphics card, the audio and the I/O sub-system.

The PovRay 3.5 test logged the time the processor took to render the default scene. Other CPU tests were the video encoding test that used Virtual dub to encode a 50 MB file into the DivX format, and the audio encoding test that employed dbPowerAmp to convert a WAV file into the MP3 format.

While the 3DMark 2001SE test benchmarked the systems that had a graphics controller onboard, the 3DMark 2003 test was used to test PCs with a graphics card. The UT 2003 benchmark was used across the board.

SiSoft Sandra evaluated the performance of the hard disk and the CD-ROM, while the Displaymate benchmarking tool assessed the monitor on features such as resolution and sharpness. The RightMark Audio Analyser (RMAA) analysed the integrated sound card for frequency response, total harmonic distortion, etc.

The PCMark 2002 test evaluated the performance of the CPU, memory as well as the hard disk. For the real world analysis, we ran a multitasking test in which we noted the time taken to open a 200 MB TIFF file, while encoding video in the background. Besides this, the PSbench test (www.psbend.com) simulated various tasks in Photoshop such as applying filters, clockwise rotation, etc. In all, the suite had 21 tests. Each test ran thrice and an average score was taken.

We ran Zdbench Davis Content creation 2003 and Business Winstone 2002 test for synthetic benchmarking of the overall system performance. For CD-Writer and Combination drives, we included the CD-R and CD-RW write speed test, and the CD-RW erase test.

Value for Money

This was computed by taking into account the system's performance and its features, in relation to the price. The higher the index, the better the PC scores in that particular category.